shaped by the United States and China. From economics to political influence and security issues, American and Chinese policies are seen as inherently conflictual, creating an uneasy relationship, even a new Cold War, between Washington and Beijing that affects other nations inside Asia and out.

The focus on the Sino-US competition for global power ignores an intra-Asian competition, one that perhaps may have as much influence in the Indo-Pacific region as that between America and China. For millennia, China and Japan have been locked in a relationship even more mutually dependent, competitive, and influential than the much more recent one between Washington and Beijing. Each has sought to dominate, or at least be the most influential state in, Asia, and the relations of each with its neighbors have at various points been directly shaped by their rivalry.

There is little question that the current Sino-American competition has the greatest direct impact on Asia today, particularly in the security sphere. America's long-standing alliances, including with Japan, and provision of public security goods, such as freedom of navigation, remain the primary alternative security strategies to Beijing's policies. In any imagined major-power clash in Asia, the two antagonists are naturally assumed to be China and the United States. Yet it would be a mistake to dismiss the Sino-Japanese rivalry as a simple sideshow. The two Asian nations will undoubtedly compete long after US foreign policy has evolved, and will do so regardless of whether Washington withdraws from Asia, grudgingly accepts Chinese hegemony, or increases its security and political presence. Moreover, Asian nations themselves understand that the Sino-Japanese relationship is Asia's other great game and is in many ways an eternal competition.

II.

Centuries before the writing of Japan's first historical records, let alone the formation of its first centralized state, envoys from its leading clan